Proposal for a Regulation on the welfare of dogs and cats and their traceability

EUCED – E.E.I.G. welcomes and fully supports the initiative of the Proposal for a Regulation on the welfare of dogs and cats and their traceability at Member State level. EUCED believes that we must contribute to common well-being, and this englobes much more than just humans. It is necessary to create measures that can defend those who cannot speak, despite being able to express themselves the way they know better; Those who should have as many rights as we do, after all, just like the five senses, we both hear, breathe, feel, taste, and see, we just have different ways of demonstrating it due to our anatomy. We are very similar in several specific aspects, different in many others, but we both deserve equal respect.
We hope that this new law gives the due importance that should be given to this subject, which is so relevant! It's not just about safeguarding the well-being of animals, it's more than that. It is teaching current and future generations to do the good in the face of incorrect situations, because the past has passed, but we are always on time to take correct actions and save lives from suffering, providing them with the same thing that we have waiting for all of us, at the end of the day when we leave work, after an exhausting day... a home, with people who love us.

The importance of looking out for others

The truth is that the values that once remained rooted in each person in the past have been lost over time, especially with new generations. But who has the fault? Nobody, or better, the guilty ones are the circumstances. It is true that over the years a lot has been improved, we have the most recent and certainly great example of Artificial Intelligence, which came to give us a boost as a society; but, in the same way that we, the most recent people, learned to work and accept this change from paper to screens, I question why there has not also been positive growth in terms of care for animal welfare? If dogs were previously seen as a beneficial element in a relationship for commercial exchange, such as hunting, why have these values been lost? The answer is nothing less than a locked drawer. New tools have emerged to help us, trying to show that animals are currently and merely used as companion animals and due to this factor, in our view, the respect that there was for them has been diminished, and they are beginning not to be appreciated.
It is time for change, and the proposed initiative establishes that animals deserve to be treated with the respect for life that any human being (even the smallest insect) deserves to have. These are basic rights.
In order for us to follow this process and for it to actually be effective and not just a few more pages that society scrolls through and does not pay due importance to, we need to re-educate our people to do good, through initiatives, or even fines in extreme cases.
We should not close our eyes when we see a lost or suffering animal, we should take action, whether is it directly if we have the power to do so, or indirectly, contacting specific authorities and exposing what is wrong.

- **Re-education & Awareness**

There will certainly be several steps to achieve the great goal of treating dogs and cats with the same appreciation that we treat our mother or father.

The centre of everything focuses on education, which must be applied from home, school, entities through public or private initiatives, as long as it is guaranteed that all information, and more than that, that all the relevance of the subject is being transmitted correctly.
Re-education must start from a young age and must be constant to ensure that it does not fall into oblivion. Currently, what is not talked about and is not news, it is interpretated like if it did not exist, and if it does not exist, the less likely the situation will be fixed. The solution could be providing speeches inviting the participation of all that are present, publicity outdoors and on the internet, encouraging the connection of a person to a dog or a cat, sharing testimonials from real pet owners, and with this, the moment that these voices are being heard, the word will most likely start to spread and taking this into consideration.
These initiatives must reach all types of targets of all ages, and if possible, it must be remembered throughout each individual's life, to keep clear the mission that should be accomplished.

- **Improvement of the surveillance**

When it comes to this topic, it should be essential to reinforce supervision, and this could be at the level of conditions to provide a home for an animal, or at a more external level of controlling illegal actions such as dogs and cat sales and the use of the female for procreation, both in order to obtain some monetary compensation through this.
The implementation of daily checks on the streets would help controlling and keeping a record of the number of abandoned animals through microchip verification and the issuing of fines to owners when its checked that an animal that does not meet the necessary requirements for its own safety; the inspection, even on a externally way, of residences in order to verify any deplorable conditions that the animals could be found, especially at times of extreme hot and cold temperatures; harder insistence, especially online, as it is through a screen that the most peculiar cases of sales tend to occur, and not only on platforms registered for the purpose of selling dogs or cats of race, always having in mind that there are many sellers who does not have the license or permission to sell, and this public usually use side ways to publish animals for sale, using applications such as Facebook, as an example of many.
Last but not least, and this last paragraph is directly connected and related to the following paragraph of this essay, which refers to the precarious use of the females as a money machine, in which female dogs or cats are constantly obligated to give birth, a consequence of abusive procreation, and at some point some can even die due to lack of conditions in which the body ends up giving in, because there is no resting between cycles. This is not built or supposed to be this way, and it is imperative that this needs to end, by having a closer control record of each female's gestation periods, or their sterilization to avoid not only unwanted pregnancies, but also the probability of serious illnesses developing over time, and death.

- **Accessibility and health monitoring**

In the society, there are various social classes, with different pockets, and by this, I mean that not every dog and cat owner, has the ability provide their pet the health care they need, due to lack of money, yet they still treat them the way we all should. They feed them and give them the essential that they need to live a happy life, and of course, to have a roof over their heads.

One of the situations that we consider most recurrent over the years, and which is in line with what was written in the previous paragraph, is the lack of accessibility to free sterilizations, which is still a problem nowadays.
There are few places that do this, but not much places that can give answer to all the pets that exist among us, which means that for example, this type of health care, is not going to be available for everyone. Sterilizations are important not only in preventing unwanted pregnancies for the females, but also in reducing the chance of the animal, dog or cat, male of female, developing problems of health such like cancer, over the years.
There is a way that we could think about it to solve this problem, which could be private clinics to perform this type of surgical intervention… but, if these clinics usually work with paid services, how can we make them help us? Our proposal is that the government of every State Member of the Europe, grants fiscal benefits to every clinic that joins this initiative, subsequently allowing us to use for free this type of service.
If we could have several places spread around the countries with this policy, not only dogs and cats would be so much healthier now and, in the future, as also they would be prevented to procreate excessively and maybe the rates of adoption could even get higher, reducing the level of abandoned animals, due to the clinics by helping when it comes to health.

- **Creation of public shelters for animals**

Not everything has to be done with money, many of the elements around us can be transformed with the help of recycling.
We currently have access to the necessary means to make changes with our own hands when it comes to collecting materials and recycling them, transforming them into animal shelters. The intention is to create several spaces spread across different countries, where animals can rest and protect themselves from the rain and the hot summer sun. These shelters can be made by gluing bottles, with scraps of fabric that are no longer being used and can be transformed into something that creates outside protection next to walls or sheltered spaces, with wooden pallets at the base.
Kennels are sometimes unable to respond to all the animals they find abandoned, and there is an awareness that not all of us have the means to be able to open our doors to more animals, but if we all provide the minimum living conditions for our animals while they don't have a home, we are already helping.
If we all contribute with what we can, we are warming the hearts of those who, despite not being able to speak, know how to express their gratitude.

- **Recognition**

As with everything in life, it is only when it is recognized that there is a problem that measures are taken to solve it, and this case of abandonment and mistreatment of dogs and cats, it is no exception to the rule.
The problem exists, it was recognized, and it came to light, so it is time for it to end and to be solved. If each of us doesn't look out for the smallest and most defenceless, who will?